

Mind the gap: on India and the Global Gender Gap Index report

India needs to ensure women's participation in policymaking

India has dropped two points from its position last year in the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Index report, holding at 131 out of 148 countries. The **parity** score is just 64.1%, making it among one of the lowest-ranked countries in South Asia, according to the report released last week. The Index measures gender parity in a country across four **aspects** — economic participation and opportunity; educational **attainment**; health and survival, and political **empowerment**. While the **performance** of India in three of the four **dimensions** **is** either **stable** or has **marginally** improved, the significant **lack** of achievement in the fourth **weighs down** the overall result. The report says, in the economic participation and opportunity category, India has improved by +0.9 percentage points. The parity in estimated earned income rises from 28.6% to 29.9%, positively impacting the subindex score, the report said. **Scores** in labour force participation rate **remained** the same (45.9%) as last year — India's highest achieved to date. In the educational attainment and health and survival categories, the scores have been **driven up** by positive shifts. It is in the political empowerment category that India records a drop in parity, since the last **evaluation**. Female representation in Parliament fell from 14.7% to 13.8% in 2025, lowering the indicator score for the second year in a row below 2023 levels. Also **evaluated** was the share of women in ministerial roles, which fell from 6.5% to 5.6 %, continuing the sinking trend since 2023.

The path ahead is **obvious** — **consolidate** and improve on the gains and make efforts to set right the **lacunae** with policies and **political will**. India has had a long, shameful **tussle** on this issue as it **toyed** with the idea of increasing representation for women in polity. The controversial Women's Reservation Bill was passed in 2023, 27 years after it was first introduced in 1996. The Bill has been **visited upon** by many **charades**, was blocked at every turn, and **the path** to **actualisation** of the goal **was** lined with **monumental impediments**. The present Act reserves one third of the seats for women in Parliament and the State **legislatures**, but will only be implemented from 2029, after the completion of the **Census**, and the **delimitation exercise**. But India **climbing up** the ranks of a global index should be only secondary to achieving a **rounded, applause-worthy**, gender parity structure within the country. There is, also, nothing keeping political parties from increasing women's participation in the **electoral** process, even before the law **necessitates** it. **[Practice Exercise]**

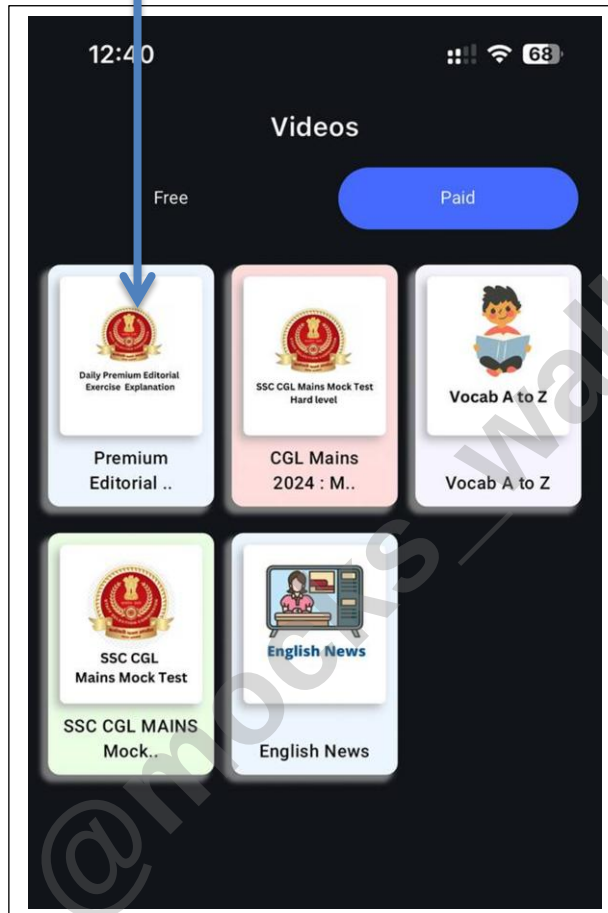
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Mind** (verb) – notice, pay attention to, heed, observe, regard ध्यान देना
2. **Gender parity** (noun) – It means achieving equal representation or participation of women and men, or boys and girls, in a specific area or context लिंग समानता
3. **Aspect** (noun) – facet, element, feature, component, dimension पहलू
4. **Attainment** (noun) – achievement, accomplishment, realization, success, fulfillment प्राप्ति
5. **Empowerment** (noun) – authorization, enablement, liberation, strengthening, entitlement सशक्तिकरण
6. **Dimension** (noun) – aspect, measure, scope, extent, element आयाम
7. **Stable** (adjective) – steady, consistent, firm, secure, unchanged स्थिर
8. **Marginally** (adverb) – slightly, barely, minimally, faintly, somewhat मामूली रूप से
9. **Weigh down** (phrasal verb) – burden, depress, drag down, overload, suppress नीचे खींचना
10. **Drive up** (phrasal verb) – increase, raise, boost, elevate, escalate बढ़ाना
11. **Evaluation** (noun) – assessment, analysis, review, appraisal, examination मूल्यांकन
12. **Evaluate** (verb) – assess, examine, estimate, judge, analyze मूल्यांकन करना
13. **Obvious** (adjective) – clear, evident, apparent, plain, unmistakable स्पष्ट
14. **Consolidate** (verb) – strengthen, reinforce, unite, merge, stabilize मजबूत करना
15. **Lacunae** (noun) – gaps, shortcomings, deficiencies, voids, flaws कमियाँ
16. **Political will** (noun) – commitment, determination, intent, resolve, decisiveness राजनीतिक इच्छाशक्ति
17. **Tussle** (noun) – struggle, fight, dispute, conflict, quarrel संघर्ष
18. **Toy** (verb) – consider casually, flirt with, dabble, ponder, experiment असमंजस में होना / हल्के में लेना
19. **Visit upon** (phrasal verb) – inflict, impose, bring upon, burden with, cause थोपना
20. **Charade** (noun) – sham, pretense, farce, mockery, bluff दिखावा
21. **Actualisation** (noun) – realization, fulfillment, implementation, execution, materialization वास्तविकता में बदलना
22. **Monumental** (adjective) – massive, huge, enormous, historic, significant विशाल / ऐतिहासिक

23. **Impediment** (noun) – obstacle, barrier, hindrance, obstruction, difficulty बाधा
24. **Legislature** (noun) – parliament, law-making body, assembly, house, senate विधायिका
25. **Census** (noun) – population count, enumeration, demographic survey, headcount, statistics जनगणना
26. **Delimitation** (noun) – boundary setting, redrawing of limits, demarcation, restructuring, zoning सीमांकन
27. **Exercise** (noun) – activity, task, process, operation, undertaking प्रक्रिया / कार्य
28. **Climb up** (phrasal verb) – rise, ascend, move up, progress, advance ऊपर चढ़ना / बढ़ना
29. **Rounded** (adjective) – comprehensive, complete, balanced, full, thorough संपूर्ण / संतुलित
30. **Applause-worthy** (adjective) – commendable, praiseworthy, admirable, notable, deserving of recognition सराहनीय
31. **Electoral** (adjective) – voting-related, election-based, democratic, polling, ballot निर्वाचन-संबंधी
32. **Necessitate** (verb) – require, demand, call for, entail, make necessary आवश्यक बनाना

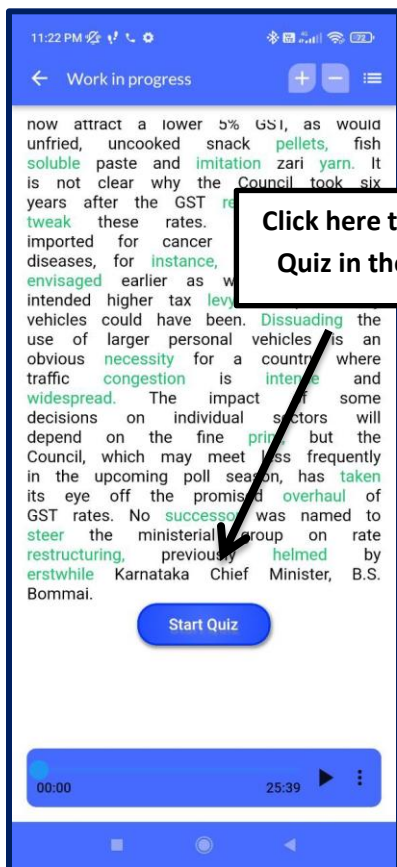
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



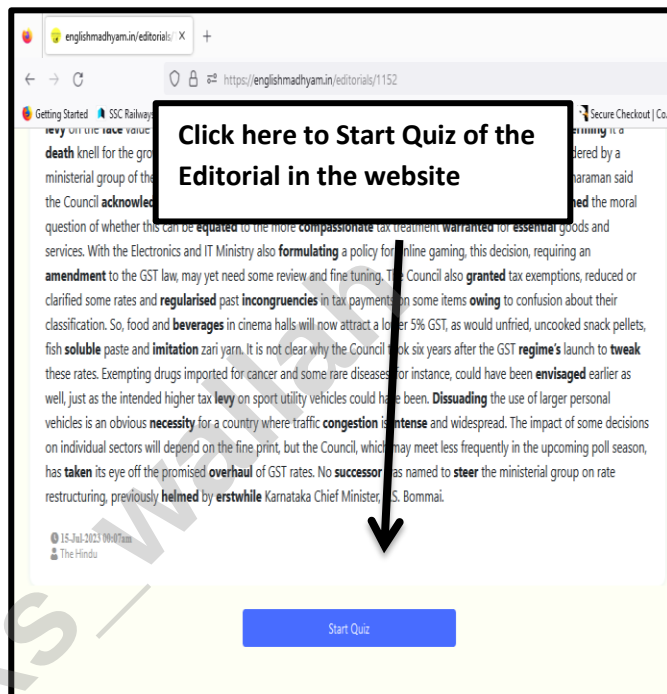
Summary of the Editorial

1. India ranks 131 out of 148 countries in the Global Gender Gap Index 2025, dropping two spots from the previous year.
2. The country's overall gender parity score is 64.1%, among the lowest in South Asia.
3. The Index assesses gender equality across four dimensions: economic participation, educational attainment, health and survival, and political empowerment.
4. India has shown slight improvements in economic participation, with a +0.9 percentage point rise in parity.
5. Estimated earned income parity increased from 28.6% to 29.9%.
6. Labour force participation parity remained steady at 45.9%, India's highest to date.
7. Positive shifts in education and health indicators have contributed marginally to the overall score.
8. However, political empowerment scores have declined, dragging down the total ranking.
9. Women's representation in Parliament dropped from 14.7% in 2024 to 13.8% in 2025.
10. The proportion of women in ministerial positions also fell, from 6.5% to 5.6%.
11. The editorial stresses the need for policy-level intervention and political will to address these gaps.
12. India passed the long-pending Women's Reservation Bill in 2023, 27 years after its introduction in 1996.
13. The law reserves one-third of seats for women in Parliament and State Assemblies but will only be implemented after 2029, post Census and delimitation.
14. The editorial criticizes the delays and political resistance that have plagued women's reservation for decades.
15. It argues that actual change must begin now, urging political parties to voluntarily increase women's representation even before the law comes into effect.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



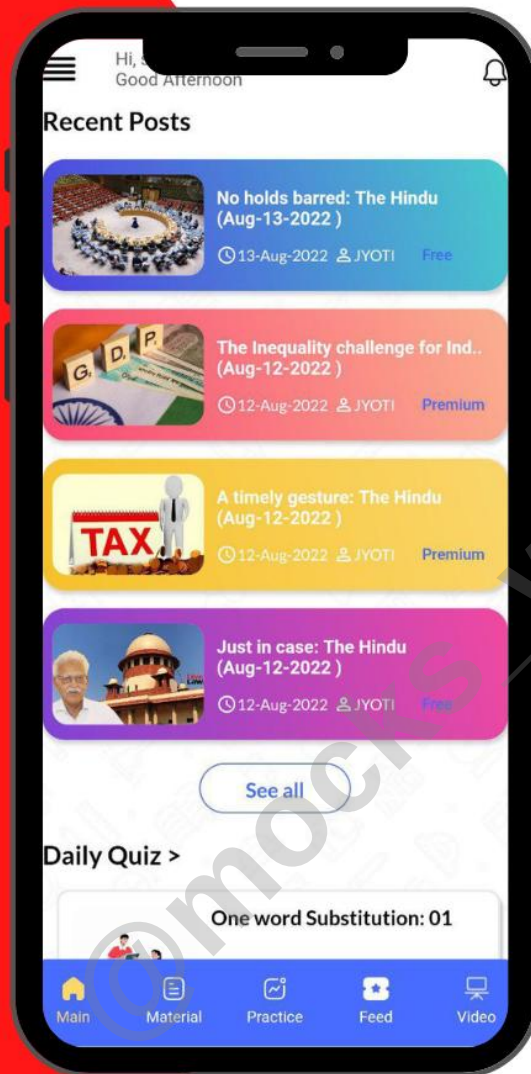
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